

Celebrating the Mid-Autumn Festival with moon cakes and red lanterns

By Cricket Media, adapted by Newsela staff on 10.09.20

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Level **860L**



The Mid-Autumn Festival, or Moon Festival, is a popular holiday in many East and Southeast Asian countries. Photo: Pixabay/Pham Trung Kien

The Mid-Autumn Festival began in China over 1,000 years ago. Today, it is celebrated by people across East and Southeast Asia. The festival celebrates the biggest and brightest moon of the year. The round shape of the moon represents being united together. Families celebrate the Mid-Autumn festival by eating together and telling stories. These include the stories of the Jade Rabbit and the Lady in the Moon. Some say that you can see their faces in the moon during the Mid-Autumn Festival.

China has celebrated the moon for almost 2,000 years. This began during China's Tang Dynasty. Different families have ruled China. Each family ruled for a period of time called a dynasty. When

the Tang family ruled China, the tradition was to look at the moon and take walks in the moonlight.

The tradition changed a few hundred years later during the Northern Song Dynasty. The Song decided to celebrate Mid-Autumn Festival on the 15th day of the eighth month in the Chinese calendar. The Chinese calendar has different months because it is a lunar calendar. Lunar calendars measure the months based on the movements of the moon. The Chinese calendar date of the festival is usually between September 8 and October 6.

The Mid-Autumn Festival is sometimes called the Harvest Moon Festival, too. Many people believed that praying to the Moon Goddess on this day would bring a good harvest. They also worshipped the goddess with round fruits including grapes and apples.

Ingredients That Celebrate The Fall Harvest

Food is always important in Chinese celebrations, but some foods have special meanings. For example, many Mid-Autumn Festival meals include a dish made with pumpkin. It is believed that pumpkins bring good health. During the Qing Dynasty, many people also began eating taro, a vegetable similar to a potato. It is believed that taro brings good luck and wealth.

Another Mid-Autumn festival treat is the moon cake. It is a flaky pastry with a sweet, sticky filling. The cakes' round shape represents the moon and symbolizes being together. The filling is usually made with seeds from the lotus flower or red bean paste. However, you can find moon cakes stuffed with other things such as ice cream, chocolate and fruit. You can also find moon cakes in the shape of squares or even cartoon characters such as Hello Kitty.

Families also prepare a Mid-Autumn Festival meal. The dishes use ingredients that celebrate the fall harvest. These include chestnuts, sweet potatoes and mushrooms.

Duck is another popular dish. Different regions of China have different ways of making duck. In the Fujian region, the duck is cooked. In the Sichuan region, people bake or smoke the duck. In the city of Shanghai, it is common to eat hairy crab. This type of crab is easy to find around the Mid-Autumn Festival.

Red Chinese Lanterns

After dinner, families gather outside and celebrate the moon. They drink tea made with a sweet Chinese flower called osmanthus and eat moon cakes.

Another favorite Mid-Autumn Festival tradition is red lanterns. In Chinese culture, red symbolizes good luck and happiness. It is an important color in many Chinese festivals. You can buy a red Chinese lantern or you can make your own. You can even use battery-powered light instead of candles for extra safety.

In 2020, the Mid-Autumn Festival was on October 1. Next year, you could celebrate by taking a moonlit walk around your neighborhood with a red lantern. You might visit a Chinese



Image 1. Moon cakes are important symbols for the Mid-Autumn Festival. Today you can find mooncake with different flavors and shapes. Photo: Pixabay/J.C. Miller.

supermarket and try a delicious Moon cake. Be sure to keep an eye out for the Jade Rabbit and the Lady in the Moon.

Write Prompt

Write a short paragraph that explains the central idea of the article. Use at least two details from the article to support your response.

Quiz

- 1 Read the following Introduction [paragraphs 1-4]. Select the sentence from the section that shows a reason WHY people pray during the Mid-Autumn Festival.
- (A) The festival celebrates the biggest and brightest moon of the year.
 - (B) When the Tang family ruled China, the tradition was to look at the moon and take walks in the moonlight.
 - (C) The Song decided to celebrate Mid-Autumn Festival on the 15th day of the eighth month in the Chinese calendar
 - (D) Many people believed that praying to the Moon Goddess on this day would bring a good harvest.
- 2 Read the section "Ingredients That Celebrate The Fall Harvest." Which sentence from this section supports the conclusion that food has special meaning for the people celebrating the Mid-Autumn Festival?
- (A) The cakes' round shape represents the moon and symbolizes being together.
 - (B) The filling is usually made with seeds from the lotus flower or red bean paste.
 - (C) Families also prepare a Mid-Autumn Festival meal.
 - (D) Different regions of China have different ways of making duck.
- 3 Read the article's Introduction [paragraphs 1 - 4] and the final section "Red Chinese Lanterns." What is one connection between these two sections?
- (A) They both say why Jade Rabbit and the Lady in the Moon are important stories.
 - (B) They both explain the purpose of Chinese lanterns.
 - (C) They both describe what families do while they celebrate together.
 - (D) They both tell how the reader can celebrate Mid-Autumn Festival.
- 4 If this article were organized as chronological, which sentence would come FIRST?
- (A) The Mid-Autumn Festival began in China over 1,000 years ago.
 - (B) China has celebrated the moon for almost 2,000 years.
 - (C) This began during China's Tang dynasty.
 - (D) The tradition changed a few hundred years later during the Northern Song dynasty.

Answer Key

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